

'Hands on History': Researching the history of the Leicester Branch of the WEA

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The Workers' Educational Association (WEA) was founded by Albert Mansbridge in 1903 with the objective of providing access to a university education for working men and women. The Leicester Branch was established in 1908, and plan to produce a history to mark its centenary later this year. Rather than commissioning someone to do this work, the Branch saw this as an opportunity to utilise its extensive archive (currently housed at Vaughan College, Leicester) as the basis for a course, enabling learners to develop historical research skills. I was invited to run this course, 'Hands on History', which commenced in September 2007 and has run throughout the academic year.



'Hands On History' research students working on the archives of the Leicester branch of the WEA at Vaughan College, Leicester in 2008.

The archives include Annual Reports, Minutes of various committees, course programmes and publicity, and records relating to specific initiatives such as pre-retirement courses, work with trade unions and school governor training. Some of the class had prior experience of historical research, but

many did not; so as well as extracting information from the archives, we have used the course to develop their critical and analytical skills, to assess the potential bias of the sources (including those available on the Internet) and to try to answer the frequent 'Why?' questions that arise from the archives.

Needless to say, we have had to identify other sources to fill in the gaps and place the Branch archives in their wider historical context. The earliest Annual Report that we have dates from 1911, but we managed to track down summaries of the earlier reports in local newspapers. Reading reports of the same event from different newspapers is very instructive in alerting learners to the newspapers' particular political standpoints – and they certainly enliven the research and help to give a sense of the place of the WEA in the wider life of the town. Commenting on a donation of £25 from the Local Education Authority, for example, the *Leicester Daily Post* declared that: 'We waste quite enough money in trying to educate those who do not want to be educated, so that – when we find our spending authority disposed to give a little towards helping those who are willing to help themselves we must devoutly exclaim "Hear, hear"...' (1)

We have also spent much time trawling the newspapers for obituaries of people associated with the Branch. Some of them were prominent public figures such as the trade unionists and local councillors instrumental in setting up the Branch, or those like Edgar Tyler, its President for many years, who was also very active in other educational organisations. Others, although appearing year after year in the Annual Reports, have been more difficult to track down – like Florence (Flo) Pole, Secretary of the WEA Rambling Club, one of the many social activities organised by the Branch, and long-serving member of its Executive Committee. Thanks to the combined efforts of several students, we eventually managed to find the notice of her death in the *Leicester Mercury*, track down her obituary, and make contact with some surviving relatives who have loaned us photographs and other items.

Oral history interviews, public appeals and learners' personal contacts have provided other information and insights that the archive documents do not offer. Thanks to a research grant from the Leicestershire Archaeological & Historical Society, one of the learners and I have also been

able to visit the WEA national archive in the TUC library at London Metropolitan University. The material here, including scrapbooks of newspaper cuttings, photographic collections, and boxes of reports and pamphlets, has been invaluable in placing the activities and concerns in the context of the WEA's work nationally, and the many new initiatives and financial and other challenges that it has weathered over the years.

We are now working on a publication based on the research, and in line with the conditions of the LAHS grant, will be contributing an article on the history of the WEA to a future edition of the *Leicestershire Historian*.



The WEA Rambling Club at Monks Kirby in 1934: archival photographic records illustrate the social activities organised by the Branch.

For me, this has been one of the most challenging but rewarding classes that I have ever taught; and it has also resulted in some unanticipated and very positive outcomes that go beyond the history itself. Realising that we knew little about current WEA students in the Branch, one of the learners has conducted a survey which has provided very interesting and (in the light of government consultation about the future of adult education) timely information about their profile and their motivation for attending WEA classes. The class was also nominated for an Adult Learners Award in 2008, and I and some of the learners were invited to meet with the relevant OFSTED inspector during the national WEA inspection earlier this year, to talk about the research and its educational outcomes.

As well as adding to the ranks of those poring over microfilm readers and searching through the indices at the Record Office for Leicestershire, Leicester and Rutland, our research has caused us, in the nature of the subject, to engage in the ongoing debate about adult learning and the place that 'liberal' education has, or should have in this. Some things have certainly changed over the past 100 years

– one advert for a course on 'The Making of Modern England' in 1910 declared that 'The class will be strictly limited to 70' – but the WEA remains the largest voluntary provider of adult education in Britain, and we have all greatly appreciated and enjoyed the opportunities for creative learning that 'Hands on History' has offered us.

Notes and References:

'Working Lives' research-based course:

Whilst 'Hands on History' is finishing during 2008, a further research-based course 'Working Lives' is starting Autumn 2008, on Tuesday mornings 10.15 am – 12.15 pm at Vaughan College. The following information has been received about this course:

Both the nature of work and the conditions in which it is done have changed radically over the past 200 years. This course offers an opportunity to explore some of these changes while developing your own skills of historical research. What did the work involve; did it have 'prospects'; what were people paid; what sort of relationship did they have with their employers; and what happened when their working lives came to an end. We will consider these and other questions through hands-on research in the classroom into original documents, oral histories and other sources. The occupations we cover will include domestic service, the hosiery industry and railway workers, but there will also be scope for you to research an occupation of your own choice. No previous experience of historical research is necessary. Contact for more information is Amanda Miles at WEA office at Vaughan College, 0116 251 9740.

1. *Leicester Daily Post*. 2nd November 1910.

FIFTH ANNUAL REPORT	
(1912–1913)	
— LEICESTER AND DISTRICT —	
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Outline information about the Officers and Committee members of the Leicester and District WEA Branch in its early years from the 5th Annual Report held in the Branch's archives at Vaughan College.